

BOGURODZICA

The two oldest stanzas and their melody
A critical edition in square notation (GregorioTeX), with apparatus

Edited from Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619

Working edition, October 2026

Status. Working critical edition. The melody follows the oldest notated witness, Kraków, BJ 1619. I collated it neume by neume against the high-resolution Polona facsimile and against Chybiński's reading (1907); they agree in every pitch. Variants from three later musical witnesses come at second hand, from Chybiński's comparative examples. Readings of the standard edition (Woronzak, Ostrowska & Feicht 1962) are cited from Marek Adamiec's digital transcriptions based on it and from two 1962 reviews. Points that only the printed 1962 volume can settle are flagged [W1962].

Edition

Cant.
I

B o-gu-rodzi- ca dzie-wi- ca, Bogiem sławie- na Ma- ry- ja, U tve-go sy- na, Gospo-
dzi- na, Matko zwo- le-na, Ma- ry- ja! Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. Ky-ri- e e- le- i-son.
2. Tve- go dzie- la Krzci- cie- la, bo- ży- ce, u- słysz gło- sy, na- pełń myś- li człowiecze. Słysz
mo- dlitwę, jąż no- si- my, a dać ra- czy, je- goż pro- si- my: a na świe- cie zbożny po- byt,
po ży- wo- cie rajski prze- byt. Ky-ri- e e- le- i-son.

Editorial bar lines (the source has no divisiones). Final *mora vocis* only at the end of each stanza. Neume grouping follows κ: climacus on -dzi- of *Bogurodzica*, porrectus on -wi-, three separate puncta on -dzi-na of *Gospodzina*.

Text

Diplomatic (BJ 1619, after Łoś 1922; q = nasal vowel)

Bogv rodzicza dziewicza bogem sławena maria
Vtwego syna gospodzina matko swolena maria
Ssiszczi nam spwczci nam kyrieleyson
Twego dzela krzcziczela boszicze
Vslisz glosi naplen misli czlowecze
Slisz modlitwq yqsz nosimi
A dacz raczi gegosz prosimi
a naswecze zbozni pobith
posziwocze raski pzbith ky'eleyson

Critical (normalised, after Woronczak)

*Bogurodzica dziewica, Bogiem sławiena Maryja,
u twego syna Gospodzina matko zwolena, Maryja!
Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. Kirielejson.
Twego dzieła Krzcziciela, Bożyce,
uśłysz głosy, napętn myśli człowiecze.
Słysz modlitwę, jaż nosimy,
a dać raczy, jegoż prosimy:
a na świecie zbożny pobyt,
po żywocie rajski przebyt. Kirielejson.*

Pilat (1879) reads *κ* differently in four places: *slawena*, *O dacz*, *prosimy*, *przebith*. The facsimile supports Łoś at *prosimi* and *pzbith*. For A/O *dacz* see the palaeographical notes. The score keeps the modern seven-syllable underlay *Ky-ri-e e-le-i-son*.

Translation. *Mother of God, Virgin glorified by God, Mary! Chosen Mother, Mary, win for us from thy Son the Lord, send down to us. Kyrie eleison. For thy Baptist's sake, Son of God, hear our voices, fulfil the thoughts of men. Hear the prayer we bring, and deign to grant what we ask: on earth a godly life, after life a dwelling in paradise. Kyrie eleison.*

Sources and sigla

Warning on sigla. Older literature numbers the Kraków copies the other way round. Pilat (1879) and Kalina (1880) call BJ 408 “Kraków I” (it was then dated 1408) and the notated BJ 1619 “Kraków II”. Łoś (1922) and later scholars reverse this. To avoid the clash this edition uses shelfmark-based sigla.

Musical witnesses

- κ* *Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619 (base text).* Added on the back flyleaf of a copy of Latin sermons made by Maciej of Grochów, vicar of Kcynia (hence the “Kcynia copy”). Woronczak dates it before 1408; it is usually given as c. 1407. Stanzas 1–2 only, with music throughout, in seven systems. Each musical section opens with a decorated initial: *B(ogu)*, *U (twego)*, *Z(yszczy)*; *T(wego)*, *U(słysz)*, *S(łysz)*, *A (dać)* (Kalina). Gothic chant notation of the German–Messine (“Hufnagel”) type, with C and F clefs and no custodes. For staff lines, clefs and doubtful notes see the palaeographical notes. Interlinear Latin in red in system 5 (*virtualis ingressus* ...) is a later addition.
- κ70* *Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, manuscript dated 1570* (shelfmark not given by Chybiński [W1962]). Late “popularised” form that tends towards B flat before cadences on a; Chybiński counts seven cases.
- GN* *Gniezno cathedral tradition.* Chybiński cites a Gniezno manuscript that agrees with *κ70* in the opening phrase. Kalina describes the “Gniezno authentic” melody, printed in *Przyjaciół Ludu* (Leszno) 4, no. 46 (1838), p. 364. It covers the whole text, uses smaller note values and sharps, and was “still sung in Gniezno” in 1880.
- w* *Warsaw, library of the Literati Chapel at St John's church, MS 998 D.* In mensural notation, so it is the only witness with explicit rhythm. Chybiński treats it as the best of the later sources. Its present whereabouts need checking [W1962].
- CZ* *Częstochowa (Jasna Góra), manuscript of the late 15th century.* The manuscript is lost and survives in a drawing reproduced by Woronczak (online in Adamiec's edition). Five-line staves carry notation for the first two lines of stanza 1 only, with a short neumed passage further down. Kalina reports variants in its first

five notes, at the end of the first half-period, and in some middle notes. It has no music for *zyszczy nam, spuści nam*. Chybiński dismissed it.

- z *Warsaw, Zamoyski Library, MS 1152 (1672)*. Mensural. Chybiński dismissed it as badly written and noted that it transmits the same version as κ70, which writes it more correctly.
- l *Latin translation Dei genitrix illibata* (early 16th century per Woronczak; text in Adamiec). Its melody is edited by Feicht 1975, pp. 187, 189, and is cited here from Flotzinger.

Text witnesses collated for stanzas 1–2

- κ408 Kraków, BJ MS 408, f. 87^v, added in the early 15th century to a codex of 1408 (*Decisiones Rotae*). Stanzas 1–14, no music.
- wa Warsaw, Biblioteka Narodowa, from Holy Cross (Łysiec), second half of the 15th century (c. 1456). 19 stanzas.
- CZ Częstochowa, as above.
- κ3 Kraków, manuscript of the first half of the 16th century (Pilāt’s “Kraków III”), with 23 stanzas.
- Ł Jan Łaski, *Commune incliti Poloniae Regni privilegium* (Kraków: J. Haller, 1506), printed in the *Registrum* as *prima omnium devotissima ... cantio*, attributed to St Adalbert. *Text only*: the facsimile shows no notation.
- M Mateusz z Kościana, 1543 (Gniezno group).
- H Herburt, 1570. s Skarga, *Żywoty świętych*, 1579.

Readings of κ408, wa, CZ, κ3, M, H and s are taken from Pilāt’s synoptic table (1879, table 7), checked against Woronczak’s normalised transcriptions where these exist.

Editorial principles

1. **Base text.** κ throughout. Three readings of the melody were compared: the facsimile, Chybiński’s transcription, and the standard modern transcription (the version circulated with the tempo marking *Uroczyście*). All three agree in every pitch.
2. **Pitch.** Transcribed at the pitch fixed by κ’s clefs: final D, ambitus C–d’, mode 1 (Chybiński). With a C clef on the fourth line, the gabc letters c d e f g h i j k equal C D E F G a b c’ d’. No flats are supplied. The only b (*spuś-ci*) is natural, and the B-flats of κ70 belong to a later layer.
3. **Rhythm.** κ has no rhythmic notation, so the score is unmeasured square notation. The mensural reading of w and Chybiński’s duple-metre reconstruction are reported but not adopted.
4. **Text.** A normalised form of κ following Woronczak’s transcription. This edition keeps *u* at the start of 1.2, as κ does and as its notes require. Woronczak’s reconstructed text of the original song omits it. Note also *dziela* (‘for the sake of’, not *dzieła*), *zyszczy* (not *ziści*) and *Bożyce*.
5. **Bar lines** are editorial and mark the verse structure.

Musical apparatus

Pitch names: C D E F G a b c’ d’; hyphens join notes sung on one syllable. Readings of κ70 and w are taken from Chybiński’s modern-notation comparative examples (1907, pp. 30–41). Rhythm is left out and only pitch content is given. “(?)” marks

places Chybiński himself flagged as corrupt.

Loc.	Lemma	Readings
<i>Stanza 1</i>		
1.1	<i>Bogurodzica</i>	κ D C F E-D-C D κ70, GN D D-C F E-C-E D w D C F E D L has D-C where κ has E-D-C on -dzi- (Flotzinger)
1.2	<i>dziewica</i>	κ F G-F-G a κ70 F G b flat a w F G a
1.3	<i>Bogiem sławiena</i>	κ c' d' c' a-G-F F κ70 b d' c' a-G F (?)! w c' d' c' a F
1.4	<i>Maryja</i>	κ F-G-a-G E-C D κ70 F-a-G-E C E D (?)! w F a G E D D (?)!
1.5	<i>U twego syna</i>	κ d' c' a-G-F G-F-G a κ70 om. d' c'; a G F G b flat a a (alternatively a G F F G b flat a) w om. d' c'; simplified four-note form beginning on a L a-a on <i>Apud</i> (Flotzinger, who suggests the same repeated a for <i>U twe-</i>)
1.6	<i>Gospodzina</i>	κ c' d' c' a G F κ70 c' d' c' a-G F w c' d' c' a F
1.7	<i>Matko</i>	κ c' a-G-F κ70 c' a-G (?)! w c' a
1.8	<i>zwolena, Maryja</i>	as 1.4 in all witnesses (Chybiński)
1.9	<i>Zyszczy nam</i>	κ F G-F-G a κ70 F G b flat a w F G a
1.10	<i>spuści nam</i>	κ c' b natural d' κ70 c' b natural d' d' (?)! w = κ
1.11	<i>Kyrie</i>	κ c' a G-F κ70, w c' a F
<i>Stanza 2</i>		
2.1	<i>Twego dzieła Krzciciela</i>	κ D-E D-C F G E C D κ70 D D-C F F G G E E C D D (?)!; “agrees with κ but badly written”) w D D-C F G E C-E D
2.2	<i>Bożyce</i>	as 1.4 in all witnesses (“repeated for the fifth time”)
2.3	<i>uśłysz głosy</i>	κ a G-F G-F-G a κ70 a G-F G b flat a w a G-F G a a
2.4	<i>napętn myśli człowiecze</i>	κ D C F G E C D κ70, w read <i>napętnij</i> , with a consequent rhythmic change; Chybiński gives no pitches
2.5	<i>Słysz modlitwę, jaż nosimy</i>	κ C F G E-D-E C D E D κ70 <i>different melody</i> , split into two halves: C G a b flat a a D D C C F F E D w <i>different</i> : C F G a (fermata) D D C F G a a, ending on the confinalis a (rejected by Chybiński)
2.6	<i>a dać raczy</i>	κ a G-F G-F-G a κ70 a G F G b flat a a (?)!
2.7	<i>jegoż prosimy</i>	κ D-E D-C F G a κ70 D D-C F G b flat a
2.8	<i>a na świecie zbożny pobyt</i>	κ c' a c' G c' a-G-F G-F-G a κ70 c' b natural c' d' G G c' a G G b flat a w a c' d' G G c' a F G a a
2.9	<i>po żywocie rajski przebyt</i>	κ a c' d' G c' a-G-F G-F-G a (from <i>raj-</i> on, identical to 2.8) κ70 a b flat c' d' G c' a F F b flat a w a c' d' G c' a F G a a
2.10	<i>Kyrieieison</i>	κ a G F F-G-a-G E D D κ70, w “of no significance” (Chybiński, no readings)

Textual apparatus (stanzas 1–2)

Lemma in normalised form. Variants are normalised unless the spelling matters; purely orthographic differences are ignored. Sigla as above.

Loc.	Lemma	Variants
1.1	<i>Bogu rodzica</i>	κ κ408 <i>Boga rodzica</i> WA CZ κ3 Ł M H S
1.1	<i>ślawiena</i>	κ κ408 <i>ślawiona</i> WA CZ κ3 Ł M H S
1.2	<i>U twego</i>	κ WA CZ κ3 Ł H S <i>W twego</i> κ408 M <i>Twego</i> Woronczak's reconstructed text (editorial)
1.2	<i>Gospodzina</i>	κ κ408 WA CZ Ł M <i>gospodina</i> κ3 <i>Gospodynia</i> H <i>hospodyna</i> S
1.2	<i>zwolena</i>	κ κ408 <i>zwolona</i> WA Ł M H S <i>zbozenia</i> CZ <i>zwolienia</i> κ3
1.3	<i>Zyszczy ... spuści nam</i>	κ κ408 WA Ł <i>zyszczysz ... spuszczysz</i> CZ <i>zyszczy ... spust winam</i> κ3 M <i>ziścisz ... spuścisz</i> H <i>ziści ... spuści</i> S
2.1	<i>Twego dzieła</i>	κ κ408 WA CZ <i>Twego syna</i> κ3 Ł M H S
2.1	<i>Krzyciela</i>	all except <i>zbawiciela</i> M [Kr]ziciela <i>zbawiciela</i> κ3
2.1	<i>Bożyce</i>	κ (boszicze) κ408 (bozide Pilat) <i>zbożnica</i> WA CZ <i>zbożny czas</i> Ł H S <i>zbożnika</i> M
2.2	<i>napętn</i>	κ <i>napętni</i> κ408 WA CZ κ3 Ł M H S
2.3	<i>jąż nosimy</i>	κ κ408 WA <i>jenżeć nosimy</i> CZ <i>jenże (cię) prosimy</i> Ł M H S
2.4	<i>A dać raczy</i>	κ (Łoś, Kalina, Woronczak; <i>O dać</i> Pilat) WA <i>Oddać raczy</i> κ408 M <i>O dać</i> CZ <i>O o dać</i> Ł <i>O o daci</i> H <i>To dać</i> S
2.5	<i>a na świecie</i>	κ κ408 <i>daj na świecie</i> WA CZ Ł H S <i>daj nam na świecie</i> M <i>dai na świecie</i> <i>dobry</i> κ3
2.5–6	<i>pobył ... przebył</i>	<i>pobyłk ... przybyłk</i> WA (Woronczak; Pilat reads <i>przebyłhk</i>)
2.6	<i>rajski</i>	raski κ
refr.	<i>Kirieleyson</i>	kyrieleyson κ (st. 2 abbreviated ky'eleyson) kyon CZ kyeon WA <i>Kyrie eleison</i> M H S

Notes

1.1 *Bogu rodzica* (κ, κ408) is two words: the dative *Bogu* is used in a genitive sense (Łoś). Pilat preferred *Boga rodzica*, the form in the 1410 *Chronica conflictus* and in Długosz. *Ślawiena* and *zwolena* are Old Polish forms without the *e > o* change, not necessarily Czechisms (Łoś, Kalina).

1.2 *U*: κ has two separate puncta *d'* *c'* here, which confirms a syllable before *twe-* (Chybiński). The later musical witnesses κ70 and w lack both the syllable's notes and the octave leap.

1.3 Kalina takes *spust winam* in κ3 and M as proof of a shared exemplar for those two texts.

2.1 *dzieła* (= *dla*, 'for the sake of'). Łoś saw this archaism as the main linguistic argument for a 13th-century date. Its replacement by *syna* in the printed tradition, and by *dzieła* in some modern editions, are both misunderstandings of it. *Bożyce* is the vocative of *bożyc*, 'son of God'.

2.4 On the decorated initial of κ see the palaeographical notes.

Palaeographical notes on κ

These notes come from my collation of the Polona facsimile, 3293 × 4699 px.

- **Staves and clefs.** System 1 has four ruled lines above the text: a C clef on the top line and an F clef on the second line from the bottom. The later systems have five ruled lines (Chybiński). The lowest of these also serves as the text baseline, which is why Kalina called the notation four-line. In system 2 the clef moves: after *Gospodzina* a C clef is drawn on the middle line for *Matko*, and before *zwolena* an F clef restores the original position. Chybiński noted that the clefs are clearest “at the beginning of the third and a third of the way from the end of the second system”. Read with these clefs, *Matko* gives *c'* a-G-F, as in every transcription.
- **Faint or invisible notes.** The C on *-gu-* (1.1) is very faded but traceable just above the text. The C on *-pełń* (2.2) cannot be seen; only one punctum (D) stands over *naplen*. The first *a* of the final *Kyrie* is faint. The ink blots over *dziela* (system 4) and after *a* (system 6) are stains, not notes. Everywhere else the reading is secure.
- **Neume groups.** Over *-dzi-na* of *Gospodzina* the *a* and *G* are written close together and the *F* stands apart. This supports the underlay *c'* a-G | F rather than a single climacus.
- **The initial of *A dać raczy*.** It has the same design as the *U* of *Uśłysz* two systems earlier: a dotted bowl on the left and a hatched box on the right. It is unlike the *U* of *U twego*. This may explain why Pilat read *O dacz*, while Kalina, Łoś and Woronczak read *A*. The later tradition splits the same way (*O dać cz*; *O o dać Ł*, H). The notes are unaffected.
- **The later hand.** Chybiński saw a cruder neume hand from *A dać raczy* onwards. In the facsimile the puncta in systems 6–7 are larger and more widely spaced, but the forms are the same, and the pitches are clear once the staff slant is allowed for.

Commentary

Form. Each stanza has three parts, two parallel lines followed by a contrasting third and the refrain (Łoś). The melody is built by varying a small stock of phrases. Surzyński (1891) labelled four of them *a–d*. Pikulik (2005) shows that Surzyński’s fifth, *Kyrieleison* motif is a variant of *d*. Flotzinger (1997/2005) set the phrases out in parallel. In his account the whole melody can be traced back to the first line, which is built almost symmetrically around a high point *c'–d'–c'*. Perz (2005) called the procedure *centonate*. The edition shows the main correspondences: the cadence *Maryja* = *zwolena* = *Maryja* = *Bożyce* (F-G-a-G E-C D); *dziewica* = *zyszczy nam* = *uśłysz głosy* = *a dać raczy*; *Twego dziela Krzyciela* = *napętni myśli człowiecze*; and the repeat of the second half of *a na świecie zbożny pobyt* in *po żywocie rajski przebyt*.

Mode. The final is D throughout, with cadences on *a* and *F*. Chybiński weighed the hypolydian (sixth) mode, final *F*, because of the *F*-cadences on *ślawiena*, *Gospodzina*, *Matko*, *Kyrie*, and the lower fourth C–*F*, but concluded for mode 1. *B* is avoided except once, on *spuści*, at the melodic peak.

The octave leap. *Maryja* ends on *D* and *U twego* begins on *d'*. Pikulik argues that this leap could not occur before the 12th, and properly the 13th, century. The later witnesses *K70* and *w* drop the opening *d'–c'* and so avoid the leap. That is most simply read as later smoothing.

Problem loci in κ. (1) *Gospodzina*: Chybiński stresses that the three puncta over the last two syllables do *not* form a climacus, since the first two are written apart from the third. They are printed here as separate puncta (*j/h/g*). The spacing in the facsimile supports the underlay *-dzi- c' a-G, -na F*. (2) The change of neume hand at *A dać raczy* makes the end of stanza 2 the least secure part of the source; the correspondence with stanza 1 is the main control there. (3) *Kyrieleison*: the underlay of seven syllables is modern. If the refrain was sung in five (*Ky-rie-e-lej-son*), the melisma F-G-a-G belongs with *-e-* and E D D with *-lej-son*.

Origins and date: positions in the literature.

- *Attribution to St Adalbert* (d. 997) is first found in 15th- and 16th-century sources, among them Łaski 1506. It is rejected by all modern scholarship.
- *Two melodies by different authors* (Kalina 1880, on the analysis of Fr Bazański). Kalina separated a “bright, periodic” first part (stanza 1) from a “gloomier” second part that he took to be Eastern in character. He found no link with the Czech *Hospodine, pomiluj ny* (Prague, Univ. Lib. 10 E 2, f. 20). Feicht’s 1962 analysis superseded this.
- *Late 13th century*, on linguistic and metrical grounds (Łoś 1922). Chybiński and Feicht place it at the turn of the 13th and 14th centuries.
- *Kyrie trope*: Woronczak (1952) identified the opening phrase with the Holy Saturday litany *Kyrie* in the Graz gradual MS 807. Ostrowska added a neumed Minden source of 1024–27. Flotzinger (2005) shows that the agreement covers only the first phrase. He adds that the Graz MS was in fact written at St Nicholas, Passau, c. 1170, and rejects the trope interpretation.
- *13th-century cento* built from litany, sequence and trouvère-style turns (Pikulik 2005). Feicht (1962) found a “striking similarity” between the opening phrase and Jehan de Braine’s *Par desous l’ombre d’un bois*, one of many parallels he assembled (Gołos 1962). He concluded that the melody is homogeneous and the work of a trained musician.
- *Late 14th century, south-eastern Poland, with Czech mediation* (Flotzinger 2005). This rests on the Deesis structure of the text and on the Slavonic-rite foundations at Prague (Emaus, 1346), Oleśnica (1380) and Kraków (1390).
- *Ruthenian origin* (Shchurat 1906; Kuzminskyi 2017). This is a minority view. It is listed for completeness and is not adopted here.

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